

Free OVI maps

Nokia has started to offer free versions of their OVI GPS navigation tool with their smartphones

Apple + Microsoft?

This has got to be a something special – rumours abound that that two rivals may finally team up to take on Google's Android

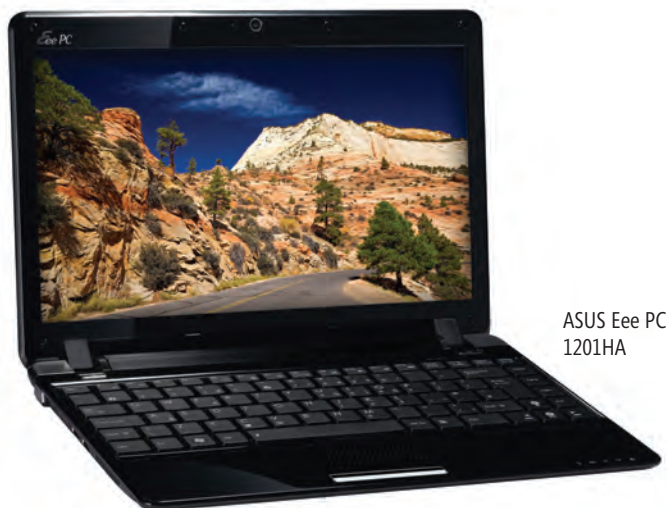
The tiny trackpad has a neat chrome trim, more importantly, it is pretty usable with good tracking and the mouse buttons are decent, better than MSI's UI30, with slightly better feedback; they're bigger as well. The Function keys are smallish, and people with big fingers will need to get used to them. The rest of the keypad elicits mixed reactions, for while the left control button is well positioned and the keys appear large, they are actually smaller than the UI30 and the spacing is also a bit less. We feel the UI30 is the smallest keys can get and still retain some usability for all but the lady-fingered, pardon the expression. The problem here is the fact that as a keypad becomes smaller, the size of the keys suddenly becomes disproportionately important. Take a much larger keypad, say one on Apple's Macbook Pro and even if the keys were 10 per cent closer or further from each other, the usability wouldn't get affected much. Gateway needs to improve their keypad design.

The screen resolution is 1024 x 600 pixels, pretty much the norm for a 10.1-inch display, but we cannot help but complain each time we see this. Performance was nothing outstanding or complain-worthy, the LT2002I is pretty much at par with other netbooks. Surprisingly, it fared badly in the Wi-Fi transfer test, although it uses an Atheros 802.11 chipset, as do all the other netbooks. The LT2002I does have a 6-cell battery; this allows its battery to go over four hours in our battery test.

ASUS Eee PC 1201HA

Shiny lover

The 1201HA is neat looking to say the least and it's finished



ASUS Eee PC 1201HA

in a pure glossy black. While glossy black finishes are a dime-a-dozen these days the 1201HA looks hot, but not as hot as the pure white version, at the expense of sounding colour prejudiced, which we are! And she's slim as well; ASUS has managed a very

sleek look, with designeresque curves and edges. The display is also pretty good, and at 12.1-inches it's larger than typical netbooks and gloriously viewable. The screen resolution is 1366 x 768 pixels – not bad. The thick bezel will bother some, but ASUS has given

this one a segregated keypad that will catch your attention. It's a good looker but doesn't function as well – the keys are slightly smaller than we'd like, and although key spacing is fine, the whole setup feels a little unintuitive while typing. Larger keys next time ASUS is all we can say. Then there's the mushy feedback, and this completes the suspicion that ASUS was trying to achieve a Sony-like feel to their keypad, since Sony uses the same segregated design and soft keys. The trackpad is reasonably accurate; but a royal pain. It has tiny dimples that immediately earn our distaste. They are abrasive to the fingerpads and very uncomfortable, and will bother the heck out of you, unless you're a manual labourer. The dedicated trackpad disable

HOW WE TESTED

Netbooks need no segregation because fundamentally the hardware stays the same. The price points do differ, but the difference is typically never more than Rs. 5,000. We logged all the specifications of each netbook and awarded points for the hard drive size, choice of bundled OS, number of USB ports and other ports and connectivity provided.

We also rated the build quality of the netbook, the usability and intuitiveness of the keypad, trackpad and any shortcut buttons. We took into consideration how comfortable the whole experience of using the netbook was, how suitable the keypad was to people with both small and large hands – an important parameter especially considering ergonomics is of utmost important with smaller sized keypads.

For performance we used PC Mark 05 and 3D Mark 05 as our primary benchmarks. PC Mark, with its suite of 48 tests, gives a good idea of overall and individual performance of each component. 3D Mark 05 gives us an idea of the performance of the CPU and graphic subsystems. SiSoft Sandra 2010 Engineer was also used to test each individual component. Our real world tests included a couple of CPU tests – WinRAR 3.9b and a .vob to .divx file encoding test. We also stress tested the hard drive by doing an intra drive copy from one partition to the other. We tested both sequential and random read/writes and the scores are displayed in megabytes per second (MBps). The quality of the inbuilt speakers and webcam were tested with a subjective test. Finally Performance Mark 7.0

was used to test the speed of the wireless component. Our battery test involves using VLC player to loop a .VOB file using full inbuilt speaker volume and maximum screen brightness. Every power saving feature is disabled making this somewhat of a torture test for the battery. For our music test, we used a couple of MP3s encoded at 320 KBps. For the webcam test we took a couple of shots, one in dim conditions, one under fluorescent lighting and took an average of both scores.

We did not award a Best Performer Award simply because there isn't much to choose from in terms of this parameter and people will not simply buy a netbook because it is 10 seconds faster at encoding videos. Please look for our detailed tables online at www.thinkdigit.com/d/feb_tables.